

Grounding Morality in Reason Alone: Reading Kant's Groundwork

An original lesson plan inspired by **Immanuel Kant (ed. Jonathan Bennett)**'s *Groundwork for the Metaphysic of Morals (Early Modern Texts)*. Not affiliated with or endorsed by *Early Modern Texts* or *Immanuel Kant (ed. Jonathan Bennett)*. Explore the original course: <https://www.earlymoderntexts.com/assets/pdfs/kant1785.pdf>

GRADE LEVEL

Grades 11-12 / Intro College

DURATION

65 minutes

TOPICS

Ethics

“Kant sets out to find the supreme principle of morality using pure reason alone, without appeal to happiness, feelings, or God — is that a coherent project, and does his Categorical Imperative succeed at it?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Trace Kant's argument, from the opening of the Groundwork, that a good will is the only thing good without qualification.
- Explain Kant's derivation of the Categorical Imperative from the concept of a rational being acting on universalizable maxims.
- Apply the Formula of Universal Law to two maxims, one that generates a contradiction and one that doesn't, to test the Categorical Imperative's action-guidance.

Materials Needed

- Whiteboard
- Excerpt handout: opening paragraphs of Section I (the good will) and two of the four examples from Section II, in Bennett's *Early Modern Texts* translation
- Maxim-testing worksheet (blank template: maxim / universalized world / contradiction?)
- Index cards for the 'good will' brainstorm

Lesson Procedure

Hook: The Only Truly Good Thing

8 min

Read aloud a paraphrase of Kant's opening lines: nothing in the world, or even beyond it, can be called good without qualification except a good will. Ask students to list things usually called 'good' (intelligence, wealth, courage, happiness) on index cards, then test each against Kant's claim by asking whether it could be used for a bad end.

Direct Instruction: From Good Will to the Categorical Imperative

20 min

Trace Kant's argument step by step: a good will acts from duty rather than merely in accordance with it; acting from duty means acting from respect for the moral law; the moral law a rational being would respect is one it could will as universal; this yields the Formula of Universal Law — act only on maxims you could at the same time will to become universal laws of nature.

Small-Group Maxim Testing

17 min

In groups, students apply the Formula of Universal Law to two of Kant's own examples: the false promise and neglecting one's talents. For each, groups determine whether universalizing the maxim produces a 'contradiction in conception' (the practice would undermine itself) or a 'contradiction in the will' (no rational being could consistently will it, though it's not self-defeating).

Whole-Class Discussion: Does the Test Work?

14 min

Debate whether the universalizability test can be gamed by phrasing a maxim narrowly enough to avoid contradiction (e.g., 'I will lie only on a Tuesday to a person named Fred'), and whether the test might produce false positives or false negatives as a result.

Closure

6 min

Return to the opening 'good will' cards and ask students to restate, in their own words, why Kant thinks morality must be grounded in reason rather than in consequences or feelings.

Discussion Questions

- 1 Kant says a good will is good 'not because of what it effects or accomplishes' but because of the willing itself — is it coherent to call something good independent of its consequences?
- 2 Can the Formula of Universal Law be gamed by phrasing a selfish maxim so narrowly that universalizing it doesn't produce a contradiction? What would that mean for the theory?
- 3 Kant distinguishes a 'contradiction in conception' (like the false promise, where universalizing destroys the very practice it relies on) from a 'contradiction in the will' (like neglecting your talents, which is not self-defeating but which no rational being could will). Is this distinction convincing?
- 4 Is grounding morality purely in reason, independent of human happiness or feeling, a strength of Kant's project or a source of its rigidity?



- 5 Kant claims the Categorical Imperative is binding on 'every rational being as such,' not just humans. What would it mean to take that claim seriously?

Assessment

Students select a maxim of their own devising and apply the Formula of Universal Law in writing, determining whether universalizing it produces a contradiction in conception, a mere contradiction in the will, or no contradiction at all, and explaining what that result implies about the maxim's moral status according to Kant.

Extension Activity

Have students research a real-world case where an institution or individual claimed to act from a 'universal principle' (e.g., a corporate ethics code or a diplomatic doctrine) and write a short analysis of whether the stated principle would actually pass Kant's universalizability test if taken literally.

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